Michael VanDyke

Technology strategist. People-first leader.

I build engineering organizations that ship software into real products, and teams that keep shipping after the launch hype fades. Lately that means AI rollouts that earn trust instead of triggering panic, cloud migrations that make on-call less miserable, and leadership where psychological safety and accountability go together.

Experience

Jan 2026 to Present

Sr. Director of Software Engineering

Vericity, Inc., Remote

Leading four software engineering teams across eFinancial and Fidelity Life, in the U.S. and Latin America, taking legacy platforms apart and moving what matters to AWS.

- Rolled out Claude Code to roughly 80 engineers, with the training and pilot programs that made it stick.
- Built an MCP server that gives our AI tools the same engineering standards our people follow.
- Built internal apps for time tracking and operations with Claude Code, proving engineers can make their own tools instead of waiting on a vendor.

May 2024 to Dec 2025

Director of Software Engineering

Fidelity Life (Vericity, Inc.), Remote

Led cross-functional teams, set the software strategy, and migrated legacy applications to modern AWS architectures.

- Won Fidelity Life's Executive Choice Award (2025).
- Stabilized critical systems and formalized the standards teams use to build, review, test, and ship.
- Helped retire key legacy systems, one of the company's largest technical burdens.
- Stood up org-wide observability and Agile analytics, and used gen-AI to document legacy code.

Nov 2023 to May 2024

Sabbatical

Self-directed, Louisville, Kentucky

Studied AI and ML through Andrew Ng's courses. Consulted for a conservation startup, mentored, and showed work in an art exhibition.

Contact

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Leadership

Distributed engineering teams
AI adoption and enablement
Legacy modernization and cloud migration
Observability
Mentorship and career growth
Data-driven decision making

Engineering

Swift and iOS
Python
TypeScript
Claude Code and MCP
Traditional AI and ML
AWS
CI/CD

Making

Woodworking
Electronics
Painting
Sculpture
Interactive art

Feb 2022 to Nov 2023

Director of Engineering

Churchill Downs Inc. (TwinSpires), Louisville, Kentucky

Led two of the highest-performing agile teams in the company: mobile engineers, manual and automation QA, and scrum masters.

- Set goals for cost, quality, and scale with marketing, product, and senior leadership.

Jun 2018 to Feb 2022

Lead Software Engineer, iOS

Churchill Downs Inc. (TwinSpires), Louisville, Kentucky

Led the team behind the TwinSpires iOS app, the company's flagship platform: iOS, QA, Java, and database engineers.

- Held a 4.8-star average across 45,000 ratings, with hundreds of thousands of users a year.
- Kept the app #1 in the App Store's Sports category.
- Built the CI and deployment pipelines, and set direction on architecture, UX, and technical debt.

Sep 2017 to Jun 2018

Lead Software Engineer, Front End and Architecture

Churchill Downs Inc. (TwinSpires), Louisville, Kentucky

- Prototyped native mobile options (Cordova, NativeScript, native iOS) with the architecture team.
- Automated builds of the hybrid iOS and Android apps, cutting dev cycle time and new-affiliate time to market.
- Led the analytics and events system for BI.
- Led multi-bonus, one of our most successful projects.

Education

Sullivan College of Technology and Design, Associate in Dynamic Web Development, 2013

Sullivan College of Technology and Design, Associate of Science in Computer Graphic Design, 2011

Certifications

AWS Certified Cloud Practitioner, Amazon Web Services, 2025

Advanced Learning Algorithms, DeepLearning.AI and Stanford, 2024

Supervised Machine Learning: Regression and Classification, DeepLearning.AI and Stanford, 2023

Talks and writing

On burnout and managing your energy, LinkedIn, 2025

Enhance Leadership Skills with UPR, LinkedIn, 2024

The Power of Pause, LinkedIn, 2024

Step Up, Sweat Down: A tale of team building and culture, LinkedIn, 2023